WORLD WAR I

BOMBARDMENT OF THE ENGLISH COAST



Date December 16, 1914
Forces Germans: 3 battlecruisers, 1 armored cruiser, 4 light cruisers, 18 torpedo boats; British: 6 battleships, 4 battlecruisers, 8 cruisers, 8 destroyers
Losses Germans: none; British: none
Location Coast of northeast England

Vice Admiral Franz von Hipper, commanding the German 1st Scouting Group, planned a raid across the North Sea against English coastal towns. If the Royal Navy responded by coming out in force, Hipper hoped to draw them onto mines laid in the area, or toward the guns of the High Seas Fleet advancing behind him. The British were forewarned of the raid by codebreakers in the Admiralty's Room 40, but unaware the High Seas Fleet was involved. For over an hour on the morning of December 16, Hipper's battlecruisers and light cruisers bombarded Hartlepool, West Hartlepool, Scarborough, and Whitby, causing much damage and killing more than 100 civilians. Shore batteries at Hartlepool hit three of the ships.

A much larger naval engagement was narrowly avoided. British forces sent to intercept Hipper blundered into sight of the High Seas Fleet, but Admiral Frederich von Ingenohl, fearing this was the Royal Navy's Grand Fleet, fled for home. This left Hipper exposed, surrounded by British battleships and battlecruisers, yet he was allowed to slip past and escape to safety. Outrage in Britain was directed equally at the Germans for shelling civilian targets and at the Royal Navy for failing in its duty to protect the country from attack.



German pistol
A Roth-Steyr M1907 taken from a German naval officer at the surrender of the High Seas Fleet at Scapa Flow in 1918.

WORLD WAR I

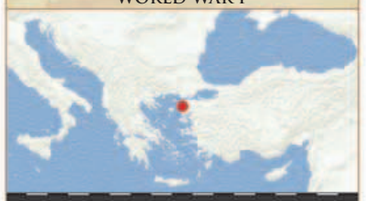
CUXHAVEN RAID



Date 25 December 1914
Forces British: 7 seaplanes, 3 seaplane tenders, 2 light cruisers, 2 destroyers, 10 submarines
Losses British: 4 seaplanes
Location Cuxhaven, northern Germany

On Christmas Day 1914 the Royal Naval Air Service executed the first air raid launched from the sea. Three converted cross-Channel steamers carried nine Short seaplanes to within flying range of Cuxhaven, escorted by Commodore Reginald Tyrwhitt's Harwich Force. The seaplanes were lowered onto the sea by cranes. Seven succeeded in taking off. Their objective was to bomb Zeppelin airship sheds, but they missed their target in low cloud. They caused some panic in Wilhelmshaven, where a battlecruiser and cruiser collided taking evasive action. Three of the seaplanes found their way back to their tenders. The pilots of the others were all rescued, three by British submarines and one by a Dutch trawler.

WORLD WAR I



BATTLE OF THE DARDANELLES

Date	March 18, 1915
Location	Dardanelles, Turkey
Result	Ottoman Turkish victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN AND FRANCE	OTTOMAN TURKEY

COMMANDERS

Sir Sackville Carden	**Mustafa Kemal**
John de Robeck	
Emile Guépratte	

FORCES

Ships: 15 battleships (mostly pre-dreadnought), 1 battlecruiser, various cruisers, destroyers, and minesweepers	**Ships:** Shore guns and mines

LOSSES

Men: 700	**Men:** 40
Ships: 3 battleships	

Naval bombardment
The pre-dreadnought battleship HMS *Cornwallis* uses her 12-in guns to bombard Turkish gun positions on the Gallipoli Peninsula. *Cornwallis* fired the first shell of the first naval bombardment of the Turkish forts on February 19, 1915.

Sinking of the Blücher
German sailors scramble onto the hull of the stricken German cruiser *Blücher* as she rolls over following heavy British fire at Dogger Bank.



WORLD WAR I

DOGGER BANK



Date January 24, 1915
Forces British: 5 battlecruisers, 9 light cruisers, 31 destroyers; Germans: 3 battlecruisers, 1 armored cruiser, 4 light cruisers, 18 torpedo boats
Losses British: none; Germans: 1 armored cruiser
Location Dogger Bank, North Sea

On January 23, 1915, Admiral Franz von Hipper took the German 1st and 2nd Scouting Groups into the North Sea to attack British trawlers and patrol boats on the Dogger Bank. Intercepts by Royal Navy signals intelligence revealed the plans and Admiral David Beatty was sent out with the 1st and 2nd Battlecruiser Squadrons to surprise Hipper, joined by the light cruisers and destroyers of the Harwich Force.

Contact was made shortly after 7:00 a.m. on January 24. Once Hipper realized that heavy British ships were present, he turned for home. Beatty's flagship *Lion* led the chase and opened fire at extreme range around 9:00 a.m. Hipper was leading the German line on the battlecruiser *Seydlitz*, with the armored cruiser *Blücher* struggling to keep up. *Lion* drew first blood, blowing up *Seydlitz's* aft turrets with an armor-penetrating shell. A devastating explosion was averted through the heroism of German sailor Wilhelm Heidkamp who flooded *Seydlitz*'s magazines despite suffering severe burns. *Blücher* also took a battering and fell further behind the rest of the German force. However, as the range shortened, *Lion* came under accurate fire from all three battlecruisers. By 10:45 a.m. *Lion* was so badly damaged she slowed to a halt.

From this point the British effort lost all tactical coherence. Four British battlecruisers poured shells into the crippled *Blücher* until she capsized and sank, while Hipper led his battlecruisers home to safety. *Lion* was towed back to the Forth, to a hero's welcome. But an opportunity to inflict a crushing defeat on the German navy had slipped through Beatty's fingers.

> "IT WAS ONE CONTINUOUS EXPLOSION ... THE WOUNDED BLÜCHER SETTLED DOWN, TURNED WEARILY OVER AND DISAPPEARED IN A SWIRL OF WATER."
>
> **GERMAN SURVIVOR** FROM SMS *BLÜCHER*, 1915

